

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

9 March 2006

To the Followers of Bahá'u'lláh in Egypt

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

Since the inception of the fifth epoch of the Formative Age of the Faith in January 2001, the operations of the Major Plan of God and His Minor Plan have steadily gained impetus and have already created far-reaching changes in the world at large and transformed the Bahá'í community. During this period, your own community has, as have others in the Bahá'í world, engaged in activities and processes that have enhanced your learning about effective promotion of the Faith. Your dearly loved, sorely tried community, established during the days of the ministry of Bahá'u'lláh Himself, blessed by the visits of 'Abdu'l-Bahá, and whose members were praised by Shoghi Effendi as "heroes in the arena of servitude", is now called to take stock and see the way forward as you stand poised to enter a new stage in the evolution of the Cause in your country.

Your brilliant record of past achievements is marked by heroism and sacrifice. The Guardian lovingly extolled you as "the second most persecuted yet resolute community established in the heart of both the Arab and Muslim worlds". In your country "the banner of the independence of the Religion of Bahá'" was first raised—a feat, in the words of Shoghi Effendi, "whose like has never been recorded in the history of ages past", and which was accomplished "valiantly, with dauntless courage and complete detachment from the world". In response to the vital responsibilities assigned in the global teaching plans of the Faith, you raised up exemplary teachers, pioneers, and administrators, as well as scholars and translators who helped enrich and disseminate Bahá'í literature in Arabic. In a special tribute to the "valiant endeavours" of your spiritual forebears, the Guardian lauded their qualities and summarized their many accomplishments, including

... their exemplary loyalty to both the spiritual and administrative principles of the Cause they have espoused ... their strenuous efforts for the emancipation and recognition of their Faith ... their assiduous labours for its propagation in their homelands ... their fearless defence of its tenets and institutions...

Your noble heritage gives stimulus to your efforts as you steadfastly carry on the work of the Cause today. Two priorities demand the attention of your community. The first is the protection and defence of the Faith, which is ably carried out by the members of the Core Group and others who have been specifically assigned to undertake this specialized work. The second, which reinforces the effectiveness of the first, is acceleration in the growth of your community, which is the responsibility of every follower of Bahá'u'lláh in that land. The accomplishment of the latter objective is urgent; it depends on individual effort and single-minded consecration to the teaching work.

The processes of the Five Year Plan—with their emphasis on study of the sequence of institute courses and the multiplication of core activities—provide you with all the means necessary to hasten and sustain a sizeable yet quiet expansion of your community. Success will require focused dedication that is expressed in regular, systematic action. At this moment in the history of your nation, your divine mission cannot be postponed. Arise, then, to engage more and more trusted members of your families, friends, neighbours and co-workers in the sequence of courses and assist them to walk the path of service. The time for action is now. Press on without delay, lest opportunities slip from your grasp.

Ultimately, success is assured by the faith in Bahá'u'lláh that animates every conscientious believer. Faith is a state of conscience imbued with a compulsion to express itself in word and deed. Teaching combines these two aspects. Surely, the forces of the Concourse on High are ever ready to confirm your endeavours.

In pursuing your activities, you will appreciate the need to act with discernment and wisdom. Do not seek publicity for your efforts. Nor should you be unduly anxious to announce the names of newly enrolled believers; bearing in mind prevailing circumstances, make known

only gradually the enlistment of those whose hearts are illumined with the light of the Revelation. Be guided by the counsels of 'Abdu'l-Bahá:

O ye servants of the Blessed Beauty!

It is a well-known fact that, owing to the frequency of disturbances, the work of delivering the Message hath been for a short time discontinued.... It is clear that in this day, confirmations from the unseen world are encompassing all those who deliver the divine Message. Should the work of teaching lapse, these confirmations would be entirely cut off, since it is impossible for the loved ones of God to receive assistance unless they teach.

Under all conditions, the teaching must be carried forward, but with wisdom. If the work cannot proceed openly, then let them teach in private, and thus engender spirituality and fellowship among the children of men....

The object is this, that in the time of peace and safety this work of delivering the Message should be carried on with the utmost fervour. But when there is no peace and safety, extreme wisdom should be exercised, though no complete cessation of effort is permissible, for in that case the divine assistance shall be entirely cut off.

... one must teach with the utmost wisdom. Should one succeed in illumining a soul through the light of guidance, one should as far as possible conceal his identity. That soul should in turn teach another and conceal the matter. My meaning is that many souls are most eager to enter the Kingdom, yet they fear exposure and publicity. For no sooner hath a soul embraced the Cause than the friends broadcast, with blasting trumpets and pounding drums, his allegiance to the Faith! Therefore, act with circumspection and purify the hearts. Behave in such wise as to become renowned throughout the world for your circumspection. Were ye to act according to that which is being written, that is, should the teacher neither mention the other believers to the guided soul nor reveal the latter's identity, no clamour would be raised, no agitation would result....

To lose no opportunity to teach, yet exercise an appropriate measure of care and circumspection, was further emphasized by the Guardian in a letter written on his behalf, in which he conveyed his wish that the Egyptian friends "should persevere in their work quietly, and seize every chance to grow, but be wary and circumspect as well, so as not to open the way for any persecutions or difficulties in Egypt".

We will supplicate at the Sacred Threshold that you may be richly confirmed in your continued endeavours. May the Hosts of the Supreme Concourse rush to your aid, and may Bahá'u'lláh bless and guide every step you take for the advancement of His Cause.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]